

Sex and relationships

You may find that you and your partner need to adapt to the emotional and physical changes that accompany pregnancy.

In a low-risk pregnancy, sex is perfectly safe, although your levels of desire may fluctuate. Most women report that their interest in sex is the same or slightly reduced in the first trimester. In the second trimester, it varies from woman to woman, and in the third trimester libido often falls.

Sex during pregnancy

During the first trimester, the hormonal changes that cause nausea, vomiting, and fatigue can naturally result in a reduced interest in sex. However, other pregnancy changes may increase your desire, such as an increased blood flow, which produces swelling in the clitoris and labia, and extra vaginal secretions. In the second trimester especially, vaginal lubrication and intensity of orgasm can increase. This may be accompanied by gentle contractions; these are normal and are nothing to worry about. Many women find that their libido falls toward the end of pregnancy since a bigger belly makes sex more awkward and uncomfortable, and they may also feel increasingly anxious about the birth.

How your partner feels

Your partner may have a range of feelings towards sex in pregnancy. While some may find their partner's new, fuller shape particularly sensuous, others may feel apprehensive about sex, fearing that they may harm the baby. Some men may feel a combination of these emotions. Unless there are concerns about your pregnancy (see [An intimate pregnancy](#)), it's generally thought that sex won't cause harm, since your baby is well protected by the amniotic fluid and your uterus.

When to seek advice

Some women experience vaginal bleeding after sex in pregnancy. This is most likely to be harmless and is often caused by the increased blood flow to the cervix in pregnancy, which can cause it to bleed on contact with the penis. If this is the cause, the bleeding should resolve after the birth. However, since there are other possible causes, report any bleeding to your doctor.

In addition to the size of your belly causing discomfort during sex, some women experience pain during sex toward the end of pregnancy as the baby moves farther into the pelvis; or they may find that the contractions during an orgasm cause discomfort. These symptoms are unlikely to be a cause for concern, but speak to your doctor if you need reassurance.

Intercourse in late pregnancy may not be safe if you've had a previous premature labor or risk factors for premature labor, such as a weak cervix, or if you have placenta previa (see [Low-lying placenta](#)), or leakage of amniotic fluid. If you have any concerns, don't be afraid to ask your doctor for advice.

Being able to enjoy sex in pregnancy will help you and your partner feel close. Psychologists have found that couples who enjoy sex in pregnancy are more tender toward each other and communicate better after the birth.